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Advancing Partnerships Between Private Sector and Development Actors in Africa

Translating social-impact opportunities into scalable and investable partnership pathways across Sub-Saharan Africa

Partnership Assessment Workbook

Developed in partnership with:

Future Africa Consulting

FCAfrica

Partnership Assessment Workbook

Word-native tools for qualitative assessment, facilitation, decision-making and learning

Organization	
Opportunity/program	
Country/geography	
Workbook owner	
Date/version	

How to use this workbook

This workbook contains the qualitative tools that sit alongside the Excel toolkit. Use it to investigate power, incentives, stakeholder perspectives, design logic, decisions and learning that cannot be reduced to scores alone.

Important
This workbook does not replace the Excel assessments. It provides the narrative evidence and facilitated process needed to complete, interpret and challenge them.

The five Word-native tools

Tool	What it is for
1. Political Economy Assessment	Understand authority, incentives, informal influence, winners, losers, commitment and resistance.
2. Stakeholder Interview Guide	Collect comparable evidence from government, private sector, finance, development actors, CSOs and communities.
3. Partnership Case Narrative	Turn diagnostic findings into a coherent partnership and financing case.
4. Decision and Action Record	Document decisions, disagreements, evidence gaps, owners and deadlines.
5. Learning and Adaptation Review	Compare expectations with results and agree what should continue, change, stop or escalate.

Recommended workflow

1. Define the opportunity and the decision to be supported.
2. Review the available evidence and identify gaps.
3. Conduct the Political Economy Assessment.
4. Interview key stakeholders using the relevant question modules.
5. Hold an assessment workshop to complete and challenge the Excel tools, using the evidence from steps 3 and 4.
6. Draft the Partnership Case Narrative.
7. Record the formal decision and action plan.
8. Repeat the Learning and Adaptation Review at agreed intervals.

Short on time? For a rapid screen, complete Tool 1 sections 3, 6 and 10, four to six targeted interviews using Tool 2, and a short Tool 4 decision record, alongside the Excel Opportunity Profile, Scorecard and Binding Constraints tabs. The Toolkit Quick Guide sets out the full sequence.

Working principles

- Evidence before assertion. Record the basis for important findings.
- Distinguish formal authority from informal influence.
- Record disagreement rather than forcing artificial consensus.
- Separate facts, stakeholder views, assumptions and recommendations.
- Do not prescribe private capital where grants, public funding or another pathway is more appropriate.
- Treat legitimacy, accountability, inclusion and local ownership as design conditions, not end-stage safeguards.
- Update the analysis when the political, institutional, financial or delivery environment changes.

TOOL 1

Political Economy Assessment

Purpose
Identify the formal and informal forces that could enable, reshape, delay or block the partnership.

Use this tool when	Expected outputs	Suggested time
At the start of design, before major commitments, and whenever the operating environment changes.	A political economy map, design implications, mitigation actions and issues for escalation.	90–150 minutes, plus evidence review

1. Assessment setup

Field	Response
Opportunity / initiative	
Geography and sector	
Decision this assessment must support	
Assessment team and participants	
Evidence reviewed	
Date and review date	

2. Context and problem definition

What problem is the partnership intended to solve?
Guidance: Describe the practical constraint, who experiences it, and why current arrangements are not resolving it.

Why is action being considered now?
Guidance: Identify policy windows, leadership interest, funding changes, market developments, crises or deadlines.

What has been tried before, and what happened?

Guidance: Record previous programs, transactions, reforms or partnerships, including reasons for success or failure.

3. Formal authority and decision rights

Decision / resource	Formal authority holder	Required approval or process	Actual practice	Implication / action
Policy and regulation				
Budget or purchasing commitment				
Procurement / contracting				
Licensing / permits				
Land / infrastructure / assets				
Data access / verification				
Risk or contingent liability approval				
Implementation changes				

4. Informal influence and relationships

Actor / network	Source of influence	Interests and incentives	Position	Ability to help or obstruct	Engagement approach
			Supportive / neutral / resistant		
			Supportive / neutral / resistant		

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5. Incentives, winners and losers

Actor / group	What they may gain	What they may lose	Likely behaviour	Design response
Public decision-makers				
Public agencies / staff				
Private operators / incumbents				
New entrants / SMEs				
Investors / financiers				
CSOs / intermediaries				
Communities / users				
Other				

6. Commitment and credibility

Commitment	Who is making it?	Evidence of authority	Evidence of resources	Track record	Credibility: high / medium / low

Commitment	Who is making it?	Evidence of authority	Evidence of resources	Track record	Credibility: high / medium / low

Credibility test
A statement of support is not the same as an authorised decision, budget, contract, procurement pathway or enforceable commitment.
High = an authorised decision plus a budget, contract or enforceable commitment. Medium = authority or resources, but not both. Low = a statement of support only.

7. Status quo, delay and resistance

Who benefits from the current system or from delay?
Guidance: Consider financial benefits, discretion, control, visibility, jobs, rents, institutional relevance and avoidance of accountability.

Where could resistance appear?
Guidance: Consider approvals, procurement, data, staffing, implementation, public narratives, community uptake and release of funds.

What events or changes could weaken current support?
Guidance: Consider elections, leadership changes, budget cycles, reforms, litigation, market shocks and changes in donor priorities.

8. Legitimacy, trust and local ownership

Question	Finding	Evidence	Design implication
Who is trusted by intended users and communities?			

Question	Finding	Evidence	Design implication
Whose participation is necessary for legitimacy?			
Which groups are excluded or under-represented?			
How will grievances and feedback influence decisions?			
Who owns the model, assets, data and relationships now?			
How should ownership and capability evolve over time?			

9. Political economy risk register

Risk / scenario	Likelihood (1–5)	Impact (1–5)	Early warning indicator	Mitigation / contingency	Owner

Score likelihood and impact from 1 to 5 using the definitions in the Excel Risk Allocation tab (row 5): likelihood 1 = rare, 5 = almost certain; impact 1 = negligible, 5 = stops the opportunity.

10. Synthesis and design implications

Three most important political economy findings

Changes required to the partnership design
Guidance: Address roles, sequencing, governance, procurement, communication, ownership, safeguards and capital commitments.

Issues requiring leadership decision or escalation

Evidence gaps and how they will be resolved

TOOL 2

Stakeholder Interview Guide

Purpose
Collect comparable evidence while allowing questions to be tailored to each stakeholder's role and perspective.

Use this tool when	Expected outputs	Suggested time
Before scoring, when evidence is disputed, or when a proposed model needs market and stakeholder validation.	Interview notes, evidence statements, areas of agreement and disagreement, and follow-up actions.	45–75 minutes per interview

1. Interview record

Field	Response
Interviewee and organization	
Role / stakeholder type	
Date, location and interviewer	
Purpose and consent / attribution approach	
Documents or data referenced	
Follow-up agreed	

2. Opening script

Suggested wording
We are assessing whether this opportunity can be implemented through a credible partnership. We are interested in what is working, what is not, who makes decisions, how demand and payment operate, what risks matter, and what would need to change. We will distinguish your views from verified facts and will follow the agreed attribution approach.

3. Core questions for all stakeholders

Topic	Questions / prompts	Notes and evidence
Problem and urgency	What problem needs to be solved? Who is most affected? Why has it persisted? Why act now?	
Demand and users	Who uses or needs the service? What evidence exists on demand, affordability, adoption and willingness to participate?	
Payment and revenue	Who pays or could pay? Through what budget, purchase, reimbursement, fee, offtake or financing mechanism? How reliable is payment?	

Topic	Questions / prompts	Notes and evidence
Delivery	Who currently delivers? What works reliably? Where are quality, capacity, logistics or continuity weak?	
Authority and incentives	Who has formal authority? Who has informal influence? Who benefits from action, delay or the status quo?	
Risks	Which risks are most likely to prevent participation or delivery? Who currently carries them?	
Roles	Which organizations are best placed to fund, convene, purchase, operate, aggregate, de-risk or provide accountability?	
Capital	What support is needed now? What conditions would be required for later-stage or commercial finance?	
Legitimacy and inclusion	Who is trusted? Who may be excluded? How should feedback, grievances and accountability work?	
Local ownership	How can local institutions, enterprises, capital providers and communities own more of the model over time?	
Success and evidence	What would success look like in 12, 24 and 36 months? What evidence would change your view?	
Next step	What is the single most important action required to move forward?	

4. Stakeholder-specific modules

Government and public purchasers

Question	Notes / evidence
What legal mandate and budget authority support participation?	
Which approvals, procurement steps and fiscal processes are required?	
How are payment obligations authorized and protected across budget cycles?	
What contingent liabilities or political commitments could arise?	
Which public outcomes and distributional effects matter most?	

Private operators and SMEs

Question	Notes / evidence
What customer or purchaser problem is commercially meaningful?	
What operating costs, margins, working-capital gaps and scale constraints matter?	
Which contract terms or standards would enable participation?	
Which risks cannot reasonably be priced or managed by the operator?	
What would make the opportunity attractive, unattractive or unworkable?	

Investors, banks and DFIs

Question	Notes / evidence
What cash flows or repayment sources are credible?	
What preparation, data, contracts, security or governance would be required?	
Which risks are financeable, and which require mitigation or allocation elsewhere?	
What ticket size, tenor, currency and return profile could be considered?	
What evidence or milestones would trigger due diligence or investment?	

Donors and foundations

Question	Notes / evidence
Which public-good, inclusion or market-building functions justify grant support?	
What additionality is sought?	
What transition or exit pathway is expected?	
How should grant support avoid distorting markets or replacing sustainable payment?	
What reporting, safeguards and learning requirements apply?	

CSOs and community-facing organizations

Question	Notes / evidence
What do users and communities value, distrust or struggle to access?	
Which assumptions about affordability, adoption or behavior are wrong or untested?	
How can feedback and grievances influence implementation?	
What role can CSOs play beyond implementation, including demand validation, trust, accountability and intelligence?	
What safeguards are required to prevent exclusion or harm?	

Communities, users and representatives

Question	Notes / evidence
What problem matters most in daily life?	
How is the service currently accessed and paid for?	
What prevents use, trust or continued participation?	
Who should be accountable when service fails?	
What would fair access and meaningful participation look like?	

Intermediaries and ecosystem orchestrators

Question	Notes / evidence
Where does coordination currently break down?	
Which actors, assets or transactions could be aggregated?	
What standards, data and governance are needed?	
Who can credibly own momentum and resolve bottlenecks?	
How should the orchestration role be funded and eventually transferred?	

5. Interview synthesis

Verified facts and evidence

Stakeholder views and interpretations

Assumptions requiring validation

Points of agreement with other interviews

Points of disagreement or tension

Follow-up actions, documents and owners

TOOL 3

Partnership Case Narrative

Purpose
Turn the diagnostic evidence into a concise, coherent case for how the partnership should work and why.

Use this tool when	Expected outputs	Suggested time
After the principal assessments and before formal approval, external engagement or detailed structuring.	A decision-ready narrative covering demand, payment, delivery, roles, capital, risk, legitimacy and implementation.	One to three working days

Writing guidance

Use evidence, not advocacy
The case should explain both why the opportunity matters and what must be true for it to work. State material gaps and conditions openly.

1. Executive summary

Opportunity and proposed decision
Guidance: In no more than 250 words, state the opportunity, binding constraint, proposed model, lead roles, capital pathway, principal risks and decision requested.

2. Development challenge and opportunity

The challenge
Guidance: Who is affected, at what scale, through which failures or constraints, and with what consequences?

The opportunity
Guidance: What practical change can be achieved, for whom, where and over what period?

3. Demand, users and payment

Users, customers or beneficiaries

Evidence of demand and adoption

Payer, purchaser or offtaker

Payment, reimbursement, procurement or revenue pathway

Affordability and inclusion considerations

4. Delivery and operating model

Component	Narrative
Core service or product	
Delivery channels and provider network	
Standards, quality and verification	
Key resources and capabilities	
Operating costs and working-capital needs	
Scale and replication logic	

5. Diagnostic conclusion

Overall deployability
Guidance: Summarise the score, rating, strong dimensions and weak dimensions.

Primary binding constraint and root cause

Secondary constraints and enabling-system weaknesses

6. Proposed partnership model

Element	Proposed design
Primary model	☐ Model 1 ☐ Model 2 ☐ Model 3 ☐ Hybrid / sequenced
Why this model fits the constraint	
Supporting model or sequence	
Core functions of the platform / network	
Conditions required for success	
What the model will not solve	

7. Institutional roles and governance

Actor	Role	Authority / commitment	Accountability	Transition or exit

Governance and decision-making arrangements
Guidance: Describe governing bodies, decision rights, escalation, conflicts, reporting and community accountability.

8. Capital pathway

Stage / purpose	Capital or support	Provider	Conditions / trigger	Transition
Preparation / market building				
Early implementation				
Scale / refinancing				

Stage / purpose	Capital or support	Provider	Conditions / trigger	Transition
Long-term sustainability				

Additionality and crowding-in logic
Guidance: Explain why each form of support is needed and what future participation it enables.

9. Risk allocation and mitigation

Material risk	Best-placed owner	Mitigation	Residual risk (1–5)	Trigger / contingency

10. Legitimacy, safeguards and local ownership

Community trust, participation and adoption

Inclusion, protection, accountability and grievances

Local institutions, enterprise participation and domestic capital

Long-term ownership and capability transfer

11. Implementation pathway

Milestone	Deliverable / decision	Owner	Target date	Dependency / condition
0–3 months				
3–6 months				
6–12 months				
12–24 months				
24+ months				

12. Monitoring, learning and exit

Key financial, delivery and social-performance indicators

Learning questions and review points

Exit, transition, refinancing or institutionalisation pathway

13. Decision requested

Decision item	Recommendation	Conditions	Approver
Approved / conditional / deferred / redesign / stopped			
Resources authorized			
Roles confirmed			
Next-stage work authorized			

TOOL 4

Decision and Action Record

Purpose
Create an auditable record of what was decided, why, under which conditions and who must act next.

Use this tool when	Expected outputs	Suggested time
At the end of an assessment, workshop, steering committee or investment / partnership decision.	Decision log, conditions, action owners, deadlines, evidence gaps and escalation items.	20–45 minutes

1. Meeting and decision context

Field	Response
Opportunity / initiative	
Meeting / decision forum	
Date and location	
Chair / decision authority	
Participants and organizations	
Documents and evidence reviewed	
Decision required	

2. Key findings

Finding	Evidence basis	Implication
Deployability and readiness		
Binding constraint		
Political economy		
Partnership model		
Institutional roles		
Capital pathway		
Risk allocation		
Legitimacy and local ownership		

3. Areas of agreement and disagreement

Areas of agreement

Material disagreements
Guidance: Record the positions, evidence and implications. Do not record disagreement as consensus.

How disagreements will be resolved
Guidance: Identify decision authority, additional evidence, process and deadline.

4. Decision log

Decision	Status	Rationale	Conditions	Decision owner
	☐ Approved ☐ Conditional ☐ Deferred ☐ Redesign ☐ Stopped			
	☐ Approved ☐ Conditional ☐ Deferred ☐ Redesign ☐ Stopped			
	☐ Approved ☐ Conditional ☐ Deferred ☐ Redesign ☐ Stopped			

5. Action plan

Action	Owner	Support needed	Deadline	Completion evidence	Status

6. Conditions and evidence gaps

Condition / evidence gap	Why it matters	Owner	Deadline	Decision affected

7. Escalation and approvals

Issue	Escalation route	Required decision / approval	Owner	Deadline

8. Sign-off

Role	Name	Signature / confirmation	Date
Prepared by			
Reviewed by			
Decision authority			

TOOL 5

Learning and Adaptation Review

Purpose
Compare expectations with actual performance, test assumptions and agree changes to the partnership pathway.

Use this tool when	Expected outputs	Suggested time
At key milestones, quarterly or semi-annually, after major changes, and before replication or scale.	Validated lessons, changed assumptions, corrective actions and updated diagnostics.	60–120 minutes

1. Review setup

Field	Response
Opportunity / initiative	
Review period and date	
Participants and perspectives represented	
Milestone or decision prompting the review	
Evidence reviewed	
Previous decisions and actions reviewed	

2. Expected versus actual

Area	What was expected?	What happened?	Evidence	Variance and explanation
Demand and adoption				
Payment and revenue				
Delivery and quality				
Partnership coordination				
Capital mobilisation				
Risk and mitigation				
Legitimacy and inclusion				

Area	What was expected?	What happened?	Evidence	Variance and explanation
Local ownership				

3. Assumption review

Assumption	Original basis	Current evidence	Status	Implication
			☐ Validated ☐ Partly ☐ Disproved ☐ Unknown	
			☐ Validated ☐ Partly ☐ Disproved ☐ Unknown	
			☐ Validated ☐ Partly ☐ Disproved ☐ Unknown	
			☐ Validated ☐ Partly ☐ Disproved ☐ Unknown	
			☐ Validated ☐ Partly ☐ Disproved ☐ Unknown	

4. Changes in the operating environment

Change	When / why	Effect on opportunity	Response required
Policy / regulation			
Leadership / institutions			
Market / finance			
Community / social context			
Operations / technology			
Other			

5. Continue, adapt, stop or escalate

Element / activity	Decision	Reason	Owner	Timing
	☐ Continue ☐ Adapt ☐ Stop ☐ Escalate			
	☐ Continue ☐ Adapt ☐ Stop ☐ Escalate			
	☐ Continue ☐ Adapt ☐ Stop ☐ Escalate			
	☐ Continue ☐ Adapt ☐ Stop ☐ Escalate			
	☐ Continue ☐ Adapt ☐ Stop ☐ Escalate			

6. Update the toolkit findings

Assessment area	Previous conclusion	Updated conclusion	Reason for change	Tool to update
Deployability				

Assessment area	Previous conclusion	Updated conclusion	Reason for change	Tool to update
Binding constraint				
Actor and system readiness				
Partnership model				
Institutional roles				
Capital pathway				
Risk allocation				

7. Transferable lessons

What should be repeated?

What should not be repeated?

What appears context-specific?

What can be standardised or replicated elsewhere?

8. Agreed adaptations and next review

Adaptation / action	Owner	Support / approval	Deadline	Success indicator

Next review date and trigger

Annex A | Key terms

Term	Working definition
Deployability	The extent to which an opportunity has been translated into a structure that capital, institutions and delivery actors can execute.
Political economy	How power, interests, incentives and relationships, formal and informal, shape who decides, who benefits, and whether a partnership can happen and last. Tool 1 assesses it.
Triangulation	Testing a conclusion against at least two different kinds of evidence: documents or data, stakeholder views, and observed practice.
Binding constraint	The main condition preventing progress. Removing secondary weaknesses without addressing it will not unlock deployment.
Bankable demand	Demand connected to a credible purchasing, reimbursement, procurement, offtake, fee or revenue mechanism.
Aggregation and Warehouse Platform	A model that pools and standardizes fragmented opportunities, assets, contracts or cash flows to create scale and financeability.
Integrated Project Preparation and Guarantee Platform	A model combining preparation, structuring and targeted risk mitigation to move opportunities toward procurement, financing and implementation.
Predictable Delivery Network	A coordinated provider system with standards, purchasing, verification, payment and liquidity arrangements that support reliable delivery.
Catalytic capital	Capital designed to absorb particular risks, demonstrate a model or crowd in additional participation.
Legitimacy	The trust, participation, acceptance and accountability required for an initiative to operate and endure.
Ecosystem orchestrator	An actor responsible for maintaining coordination and momentum across institutions from design through execution.
Local ownership	Meaningful local control, capability, participation, value capture and accountability, including through institutions, enterprises, communities and domestic capital.

Annex B | Evidence classification

Classification	Meaning	How to use it
Verified fact	Supported by a reliable document, dataset, contract, record or independently corroborated source.	Use directly and cite the evidence.
Stakeholder view	A participant's interpretation, preference or experience.	Attribute it and compare it with other evidence.
Assumption	A proposition treated as true for design or modelling but not yet demonstrated.	Record it and define how it will be tested.
Recommendation	A proposed response based on the available evidence and judgement.	State the rationale, owner and decision required.
Evidence gap	Important information is unavailable, outdated, disputed or insufficient.	Do not guess. Assign an owner, method and deadline.